

Διονύσιος ὁ Συρακόσιος ὁ Πρεσβύτερος

Dionysius of Syracuse the Elder and the Philosopher-Tyrant

eul_aid: eii

Period: *Κλασική* [Classical](#)
Dialect: *Δράμα Ἀττικόν* [Attic Drama](#)
Domain: *Δρᾶμα* [Drama](#)
Format: *Ἑμμετρος* [Verse](#)

Dionysius the Elder was tyrant of Syracuse from 405 BCE until his death. He seized power during the crisis of a Carthaginian invasion of Sicily and ruled through nearly continuous warfare, consolidating Syracusan dominance on the island by 392/1 BCE. His reign was characterized by major military fortifications, a powerful navy, and a court that attracted intellectuals such as the historian Philistus and the philosopher Plato, as Dionysius sought to cultivate the image of a legitimate Hellenic ruler.

His only known literary work is the tragedy **The Ransom of Hector**, which is now lost and survives only in references. Dionysius I was a transformative military and political figure who made Syracuse the preeminent power in the Greek West. His attempts to gain prestige as a tragic poet, though often mocked in later anecdotal tradition, underscore the interplay between political authority and cultural ambition in the Classical period.

Works (1)

- *Ἀποσπάσματα φιλοσοφικῶν γνώμῶν* · [Fragments of Philosophical Maxims](#) · 26 passages